



Lecture 2

TECHNICAL Report Writing

Top Down Approach

Top Down Approach

- Top-down means putting the main idea first.
 - Putting the main idea first establishes the context and the outline of the discussion.
 - In a document the introduction is the top because it announces the purpose of the document.
 - In addition, the list at the end of the introduction sets up the organization of the rest of the document
 - When the reader finishes the first paragraph, she or he has a clear expectation of what will happen in the rest of the message.

Importance of Top Down Approach

- Readers tend to grasp information better if you arrange items in top-down order.
- Top-down messaging is especially important in Web documents, because Web readers have a tendency to scan information on a page.
- If they don't see what they're looking for right away, they will often navigate away from your page and find something else that gives them more quickly the information they seek.



Design the Appearance

- Designing the appearance means creating a page that helps readers locate information and see the relationship among various pieces of information.
- You can tell immediately by the design, that the message has two main divisions, that the first division has two subdivisions, and that the text in the second division is supported by a visual aid.

Top

List two major sections of the document

Primary subdivision

Secondary subdivisions

Primary subdivision

Technical writing is the practical writing that people do on their jobs. The goal of technical writing is to help people get work done. This report explains two key characteristics of technical writing: audience centered and designed.

Audience Centered. Writing is audience centered when it focuses on helping the audience. To help the audience, the writer must help the reader act and must remember community values.

Help Act. Writing helps readers get a job done or increase their knowledge so that they can apply it another time in their job.

Community Values. Everyone who belongs to any organization agrees with or lives by some of that organization's values. The writer must be sure not to offend those values.

Designed. Technical writing appears in a more designed mode than many other types of writing. Design strategies help readers grasp messages quickly. Three key strategies are the top-down approach, the use of heads, and the use of chunks. Figure 1 illustrates the two methods. The first sentence is the top, or main, idea. The boldfaced words are the heads, which announce topics, and the x's represent the chunks or ideas.

Design the Appearance

- Technical writers use this kind of design to make the message easy to grasp
- The basic design items that writers use are
 - ▶ Headings
 - ▶ Chunks
 - ▶ Visual aids
 - ▶ Hyperlinks

Headings

- Headings, or heads, are words or phrases that name the contents of the section that follows.
- Heads are top-down devices.
- They tell the reader what will be treated in the next section.
- They also indicate where the units begin and ends.
- As a result, the readers always have a “map” of the document.

Chunks

- A chunk is any block of text.
- The basic idea is to use a series of short blocks rather than one long block
- Readers find shorter chunks easier to grasp.
- Chunking is a strategy used to improve memory performance. It helps you present information in a way that makes it easy for your audience to understand and remember.
- So Chunking allows people to take smaller bits of information and combine them into more meaningful, and therefore are more memorable.

Chunking (writing)

- **Chunking** is a method of presenting information which splits concepts into small pieces or "chunks" of information to make reading and understanding faster and easier.

Chunked content usually contains:

- Bulleted lists
- Short subheadings
- Short sentences with one or two ideas per sentence
- Short paragraphs, even one-sentence paragraphs
- Easily scannable text, with bolding of key phrases
- Inline graphics to guide the eyes or illustrate points which would normally require more words

Visual Aids.

- Visual aids—graphs, tables, and other media—appear regularly in technical writing.
- Documents that explain experiments or projects almost always include tables or graphs.
- Manuals and sets of instructions rely heavily on drawings and photographs, and those delivered in digital format may include audio or video clips.
- Feasibility reports often include maps of sites.

Visual Aids.

- Writers commonly use visual aids to present
 - Collections of numerical data (tables),
 - Patterns or trends in data (graphs),
 - Examples of action (a short video clip showing how to connect to a computer network).

Hyperlinks.

- Specific to Web documents, hyperlinks are words embedded in the document that help the reader navigate to more information about a subject.
- Denoted by a different-colored text and are typically underlined.
- Clicking on a hyperlink within a document will take you to a different page—or a different location on the same page
- That contains more information about the highlighted word or phrase.
[hyperlink](#)



END